TFL - London Underground: Post Covid Recovery

The London Underground lost 94% of its passengers during COVID, has recovered to only 88% five years later, and the data proves that hybrid working and other human factors has permanently changed how London commutes with Monday ridership 12.4% below the rest of the week.

Before COVID, London's Tube carried about 1.4 billion journeys a year. It was the backbone of the city with 270 stations including 11 lines and millions of people packed into trains every morning and evening.

Then in March 2020 due to COVID the ridership dropped 94%. The Tube went from carrying 100 million people per month period to just 5.7 million. Stations that normally had 40,000 people passing through daily had almost nobody.

Five years later, people came back but not all of them, and not in the same way. The Tube now carries about 1.2 billion journeys a year which is roughly 88% of what it did before. That 12% gap might sound small, but it represents about 170 million missing journeys every year. The recovery has slowed down. Growth slowed from 11% to just 3% in the most recent year. It looks like this is the new normal, not a temporary dip.

THE INSIGHTS:

Only 7% of Tube stations have fully recovered

Of the 265 Underground stations I analysed, only 18 have returned to or exceeded their 2019 passenger levels. 138 stations are in partial recovery at 75-90% of pre-COVID levels. And 84 stations are still below 75% which is more than a quarter of their passengers that simply never came back.

If you're TfL planning staff rotas, train frequencies, or maintenance schedules, you can't treat the network as one thing anymore. Some stations need the same resources as before. Others could probably run with fewer staff and less frequent trains.

The **Elizabeth Line** has been a game changer.

The stations that grew beyond 2019 levels tell a clear story:

- **Farringdon: +52%**: This station was transformed by the Elizabeth line opening. It went from a minor Thameslink stop to a major interchange. The growth has nothing to do with COVID recovery and is a new infrastructure creating new journeys.

- **Tottenham Court Road: +42%**: Same story. Elizabeth line turned it into a West End superstation.
- **Whitechapel: +34%** — Elizabeth line again. Pattern is obvious.
- **Richmond: +42%, Wimbledon: +33%** — These are areas that exist a bit outside inner London. People who used to commute 5 days a week now come in 3-4 days, but these stations also serve leisure travellers, shoppers, and people visiting at weekends.

The stations with the worst recovery are concentrated in London's traditional business districts:

- **Chancery Lane: -52%**: Serves the legal district and Holborn offices. Half the passengers are gone.
- **Barbican: -51%**: Right at the edge of the City of London financial district.
- **Cannon Street: -42%**: A pure commuter station serving the Square Mile. No leisure demand to compensate.
- **Old Street: -42%**: The heart of "Silicon Roundabout," London's tech hub. Tech workers were the earliest and most complete adopters of remote working.
- **Lancaster Gate: -55%**: Tourist-heavy (near Hyde Park) but also office workers. The tourist recovery helped, but office commuters didn't return.

If a station's primary purpose was getting office workers to their desks between 8 and 9am, it's still deeply below pre-COVID levels. The people who worked in those offices haven't come back five days a week and the data says they probably never will.

Monday

The 2024 station data separates Monday from Tuesday-Thursday for the first time. Across all 265 Underground stations, Monday entries are 12.4% lower than the Tuesday-Thursday average. That's not a small difference and it's roughly one in eight commuters choosing not to travel on Mondays.

At some City stations, the gap is even larger:

- Stations serving the financial district show Monday gaps of 20-25%

- That means one in four or five weekday commuters simply doesn't come in on Mondays

London has collectively settled on a hybrid working pattern. The most common arrangement is "work from home Monday and/or Friday, come to the office Tuesday to Thursday."

The 2019 data has none of this Monday split. In 2019, there was no reason to separate Monday from any other weekday because they were all the same. TFL only started measuring this split because hybrid working changed the pattern.

Buses are losing, the Tube is gaining, but neither is back to normal.

Before COVID (2010-2019):

- Buses dominated at 64% of all TFL journeys but were slowly declining.
- The Tube was growing its share from 31% to 35%.
- Total journeys were growing because London's population was growing.

During COVID (2020-2021):

- Everything collapsed, but buses held up better than the Tube
- Bus share surged to 67% because essential workers (NHS staff) relied on buses.
- The Tube dropped to 23% share because nobody was commuting to offices.

After COVID (2022-2025):

- Bus share has fallen to 51% which is its lowest level ever.
- Tube share has recovered to 34%.
- But total journeys across all modes are still below 2019.

Buses aren't losing passengers to the Tube, they're losing them to cycling (up 43% since 2019) and walking. The Tube is recovering because office workers are coming back to an extent, but buses serve a different market (shorter trips, areas without Tube access) that is shrinking as people walk and cycle more.

The Numbers:

- Pre-COVID peak: **1,385 million** Tube journeys (2018/19)
- COVID low: **296 million** (2020/21) **79% collapse**
- Current: **1,218 million** (2024/25) **88% of peak**
- **265 LU stations** matched across 3 years
- Fully recovered: **18 stations (7%)**
- Still below 75%: **84 stations (32%)**
- Monday gap: **-12.4%** below Tuesday-Thursday average
- Biggest winner: **Farringdon +52%** (Elizabeth line)
- Biggest loser: **Lancaster Gate -55%** (office/tourist)
- Bus share now: **51%** (all-time low)
- Tube share now: **34%** (recovering toward pre-COVID 35%)

Terms:

Annualised entry/exit count — The total number of people entering and exiting a station over a full year, calculated by weighing typical daily counts (weekdays × 253, Saturdays × 52, Sundays × 59).

Financial year: TfL's financial year runs April to March. So, 2024/25 means April 2024 to March 2025.

Reporting period: TfL divides each financial year into 13 periods of 4 weeks each (not calendar months). Period 1 starts in April.

Recovery percentage: A station's 2024 annual passengers divided by its 2019 passengers, times 100. If a station had 10 million in 2019 and 8 million in 2024, its recovery is 80%.

Monday gap / Monday effect: The percentage difference between Monday entries and Tuesday-Thursday entries at a station. Negative means Monday is quieter. A gap of -15% means Monday has 15% fewer passengers than a typical midweek day.

Mode share: The percentage of all TFL journeys made by one transport mode. If the Tube carries 340 million out of 1,000 million total journeys, its mode share is 34%.

Lost customer hours (LCH): TFL's measure of total delay impact. If 1,000 people are each delayed by 6 minutes, that's 100 lost customer hours. Lower is better.

Excess journey time: The difference between how long a journey actually takes and how long it would take if everything ran perfectly. Measured in minutes. Lower is better.